EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 13 OCTOBER 2026

Windsor, Colorado

El Niño barely changes Windsor's winter. What kills here is carbon monoxide in an outage, a heart attack behind a snow shovel, and a March blizzard after everyone has stood down. The single most important step is to get combination smoke and carbon monoxide alarms installed, not handed out, in the homes of older and low-income residents before the first cold snap.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Not resolved. The town straddles Weld County (mostly) and Larimer County. It had 18,644 people in 2010 and an estimated 40,349 in 2023	None published for the US, Colorado, or either county	n/a here. The global 6-month figure is 239,000 ± 11,000 (heat only)	Cold snaps, outages, and carbon monoxide; single large upslope snowstorms in October and March; wind-driven grass fire in drought

20/20 recommendations checked. 1 confirmed, 14 corrected, 3 unverified, and 2 contraindicated. Both contraindicated items were funding placements: a ZIP-restricted furnace gift that would duplicate a state programme, and overflow money aimed at a shelter that no longer hosts overflow. **The funding target fell 58% in verification**, from $155,000 to $65,000. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review. It covers heat only and publishes no US figure, so this

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



40.48°N 104.90°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** El Niño barely changes this winter; what kills is carbon monoxide in an outage, a heart attack behind a snow shovel, and a March blizzard after everyone has stood down.
- **First action.** The American Red Cross and Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue install combination smoke and carbon monoxide alarms in older and low-income homes by 1 December, with Spanish-first warnings.
- **The money.** $30,000 floor, $65,000 target, $160,000 ceiling; the floor installs alarms in about 400 homes.
- **Do not.** Do not tell people to "get a generator", or run one in the garage with the door open: a Broomfield man died with a generator running in his garage.*

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report gives no excess-death number, scaled or otherwise. **Read this first:** the El Niño signal for northern Colorado is weak, and the official sources disagree even on its direction. The Colorado Climate Center finds El Niño's strongest Colorado signal is *below*-average winter temperature, with no precipitation signal. CPC's 17 September 2026 outlook favors *above*-normal temperatures across the northern tier, and its next issue is due 15 October. Every action below pays off in an ordinary winter too. That is deliberate.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO

RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. Backing lenses are shown per action; an action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet.

1. Install combination smoke and carbon monoxide alarms in older and low-income homes, with Spanish-first warnings about generators, heaters, and idling cars

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
American Red Cross, Northern Colorado (installs), with Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue referring homes	1 December 2026	$30,000 for about 400 homes at about $75 each (unverified unit cost)	Carbon monoxide deaths in outages and storms, and night-time fire deaths

Installation beats giveaway. For smoke alarms, installation costs $45,630 per QALY against $51,404 for giveaway (Liu, Mack, and Diekman, *Am J Prev Med* 2012). Baltimore's door-to-door programme cost about $28,252 per death averted (Diamond-Smith et al., *Injury Prevention* 2014). Colorado's 2009 law (HB09-1091) requires carbon monoxide alarms only at sale, at a new tenancy, or during permitted work. State alarm laws have shown no measurable effect on carbon monoxide deaths (Hampson 2016; *Clin Toxicol* 2023), so the gap is working alarms in actual homes. In Connecticut's storm outbreaks, Hispanic patients made up 28–37% of carbon monoxide cases, against 12% of the population. Weld County is 32.6% Hispanic.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the lens credited the $28,252 figure to Liu; it is Diamond-Smith. Both studies measure *smoke* alarms. The carbon monoxide half rests on mechanism, not outcome data. Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue lists no installation programme, but the Red Cross installed about 200 alarms with Greeley Fire in June 2025, so it is the proven installer. The money's distinct value is the carbon monoxide half of a combination alarm. No current Colorado count of carbon monoxide deaths was found; the last state study (1986–91) found about 29 a year.

2. Run a sign-up drive for CodeRED and NOCO Alert aimed at cell-only households and anyone who registered after March 2025, then send an opt-in test and measure who gets it

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Weld County OEM and LETA (which runs NOCO Alert), with volunteers at the pantry and the recreation center	**Drive in November; test by 1 December**	**Staff and volunteer time**	**A repeat of 2008, when tornado warnings reached some people by email "long after the storm had passed"**

Windsor and Greeley chose not to install outdoor sirens after the 2008 tornado, so phone alerts are the town's warning system. NOCO Alert, run by LETA, includes landlines automatically, but cell, text, and email are opt-in. Weld's CodeRED went offline on 10 November 2025 after a cyberattack and was rebuilt on Crisis24's platform by mid-December. Subscribers were restored from a 31 March 2025 backup, so only people who signed up after that date, or who are not sure, need to register again. Wireless Emergency Alerts reach every phone in the target area without sign-up, and LETA can send them.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The town has more than doubled since 2010, so most households have no memory of 2008. A live Wireless Emergency Alert test needs FEMA's IPAWS test procedures and approval, so plan the drill as an opt-in CodeRED and NOCO Alert test. A table outside the pantry (1051 Walnut St) and the recreation center (250 N 11th St) reaches people where they already are.

3. After any storm of 20 cm (8 in) or more, clear snow for older men with heart disease, through the county chore programs plus named snow buddies on each street

CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · EMERGENCY MANAGER | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Weld County Area Agency on Aging (Chore Service) and Larimer County Office on Aging (Chore Voucher), with neighborhood volunteers	Lists built by 1 December	Existing county vouchers; volunteers	Heart attacks while shoveling

In Quebec, men had higher odds of dying of a heart attack the day after 20 cm of snow (OR 1.34, 95% CI 1.26–1.42), and of being admitted for one (OR 1.16). Women showed no effect (Auger et al., *CMAJ* 2017). About 17–18% of Windsor residents are 65 or older. Weld's Chore Service is for people 60 and over, needs an assessment, and reimburses through vouchers ((970) 400-6133). Larimer's Chore Voucher has a waiting list.

The evidence comes from a snowy northern climate like this one. No study has measured the effect of a snow-clearing service itself. Weld's program does not cover the Larimer side of town, so volunteer snow buddies fill that gap.

4. Keep winter staffing, plows, and shelter agreements in place through 30 April, not February

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Town of Windsor, with both county OEMs	Decide now; hold to 30 April 2027	Contract terms, not new money	Being caught stood down by a March storm

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

March is Fort Collins' snowiest month, with a 1991–2020 normal of 9.3 in. The El Niño-year storms here came at the edges of the season: Christmas Eve 1982, 24–25 October 1997, 17–19 March 2003 (32.2 in at CSU), and 13 March 2019. The money runs out in spring too. The state's cold-weather shutoff rule stops applying when the weather warms, and LEAP closes on 30 April.

Greeley's snowiest month and the April normal were not checked.

5. Get medical certificates on file with Xcel for oxygen and powered-device users, start LEAP sign-ups on 1 November, and ask Poudre Valley REA to adopt a temperature trigger

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Weld and Larimer human services; St. Alban's Church in Windsor (LEAP help); clinics (certificates)	**Before the first 32°F forecast; LEAP from 1 November**	**A clinic visit per certificate; staff time**	**Disconnection, and power-device failure during outages and shutoffs**

Utilities regulated by the Colorado PUC, such as Xcel, must *postpone* a residential disconnection when the 6–9am National Weather Service forecast shows 32°F or lower within 24 hours. The postponement defers the bill; it does not cancel it. A medical certificate holds off a shutoff for 90 days, plus one 90-day extension. Xcel's Medical Certification and Medical Exemption programs add advance warning of public safety power shutoffs, and enrollees in high wildfire-risk zones can get a backup-battery rebate of up to $10,000. Windsor is split between Xcel and Poudre Valley REA, a cooperative with its own rules: a 60-day medical hold plus 30 days, and no temperature trigger found. LEAP runs from 1 November to 30 April. In 2024–25 it reached nearly 80,000 Coloradans at an average of $355.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The federal money behind LEAP is unsettled. A continuing resolution funds the government only to 11 December 2026, and the President's FY2027 request zeroes LIHEAP. The House subcommittee bill gives $4.055 billion. Energy Outreach Colorado's free furnace repair requires LEAP approval, so enrolling people in LEAP is also the route to it.

6. Put local closure triggers for I-25, US-34, and SH-392 in writing, building on what CDOT and the State Patrol already do, and name warming shelters near the exits

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
CDOT and the Colorado State Patrol, with both county OEMs and Windsor Police	15 November 2026	Staff time	Carbon monoxide deaths in stranded vehicles, and responders killed at the roadside

In the 13 March 2019 bomb cyclone, I-25 closed from Wellington to the Wyoming line after a pileup of about 100 vehicles, and about 1,100 motorists were stranded statewide. Colorado State Patrol Cpl. Daniel Groves was killed on I-76 in Weld County while helping a driver who had slid off the road. In the October 1997 blizzard, three of the El Paso County deaths were carbon monoxide poisoning in stranded vehicles.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

CDOT already closes highways early when blizzard conditions are possible (its 2019 "shelter sooner" guidance). So this is about writing down the local triggers and naming the shelters, not inventing a protocol. Dairy, meatpacking, and oil-and-gas employers should agree to cancel shifts on blizzard warnings.

7. Carry winter-safety messages in Spanish through trusted voices: El Tigre radio, parish priests, and dairy employers. Say plainly that no one will be asked their status

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue (content), with KGRE, local parishes, and two or three dairies	November 2026	Near nil; airtime may be donated	Carbon monoxide and cold deaths among households that avoid officials

KGRE "El Tigre" (1450 AM, Greeley) was the community's information line during the December 2006 Swift raid. After that raid, families avoided social services. Hispanic residents are over-represented in storm-related carbon monoxide cases.

The station listings are dated, so call before relying on the airtime. The figure of about 6,370 farmworkers in Weld could not be confirmed. No 2025–26 Weld data show enforcement fear reducing service uptake, though drops were reported elsewhere.

8. Pantries: drop the proof-of-address request for USDA food, which the rules already require, and give the Weld Food Bank cash by 15 December rather than food

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Windsor-Severance Food Pantry; Weld Food Bank	Now (address rule); 15 December (cash)	$10,000 (see funding)	Farmworker and newcomer households being turned away in a storm week

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The Windsor-Severance Food Pantry (1051 Walnut St; open Tuesday and Thursday, 9am to noon; 970-329-1588) asks for "a piece of mail with name and address." Since 30 December 2024, federal rules (7 CFR 251.5(b)(3)) have barred requiring an address or ID to receive TEFAP food; self-attestation is allowed. Weld Food Bank reports about 30,000 visits a month and a possible $700,000 shortfall. Its stated gaps are cash and cold-chain trucks, not shelf space. On the third day of the November 2025 SNAP lapse it served about 2,200 people.

Food the pantry buys outside TEFAP can keep its own rules. Colorado's TEFAP state plan was not retrieved.

9. Screen SNAP recipients aged 55–64, and parents of teenagers, for exemptions from the work rules

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED (ALREADY LATE) | FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Weld and Larimer human services	Now	Staff time	Households losing food benefits during the winter peak

Under H.R.1, the three-month SNAP time limit now applies to adults aged 18–64, and only parents of children under 14 are exempt. Colorado has enforced it since 1 November 2025, with no waiver. Weld had about 39,238 SNAP recipients in October 2025.

The Food Supply Chain lens's one thing: federal policy will hurt Windsor households more than the weather will this winter. It is not an El Niño action, and it belongs here because nothing else in this list reaches as many people.

10. Fund hotel overflow for the Weld cold-weather shelter on nights it is full

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED (RECIPIENT CORRECTED) | PHILANTHROPIST · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
United Way of Weld County Cold Weather Shelter (870 28th St, Greeley), staffed by Catholic Charities	Season runs 1 November – 15 April	$15,000	Hypothermia deaths among unhoused adults

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

In December 2024 the shelter had 60 beds, ran at capacity, and had "some funds" for hotel overflow (Weld Area Agency on Aging minutes). In metro Denver, 8 of 233 homeless deaths in 2018 were from hypothermia (Colorado Coalition for the Homeless count). Windsor has no shelter of its own.*

No Weld or Larimer temperature threshold for activating cold-weather shelter was found.

11. List the large flat roofs (schools, the recreation center, commercial and agricultural buildings) and set a snow-depth trigger for clearing them

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Town of Windsor building department, with Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue	15 December 2026	Staff time	Roof collapse under wet spring snow

The March 2003 storm's wet snow collapsed more than 100 roofs in Denver (NASA), and the National Weather Service reported at least 258 structures damaged there. In Fort Collins, 37 structures were destroyed and more than 200 badly damaged, according to a secondary account.

The free HHS emPOWER data can add a list of power-dependent residents to the same exercise.

12. On dry, windy Red Flag days, staff brush trucks and pre-plan evacuation for the grassland edge. Check addresses against Xcel's shutoff map

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue	Now, through spring	Existing budget	A wind-driven grass fire reaching the subdivisions

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Colorado is about 86% in drought. The Marshall Fire burned on 30 December 2021, in a La Niña winter. In Xcel's public safety power shutoff of 6–7 April 2024, 55,000 customers lost power on purpose. The PUC investigated and ordered improvements (docket 24M-0173E).

Whether Windsor sits inside a shutoff zone is unverified. Check addresses on Xcel's map.

13. Run a high-dose flu, COVID, and RSV vaccination drive for people 65 and over in October

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED (CLAIM SCALED DOWN) | PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Weld and Larimer public health, with pharmacies	October–November 2026	Covered by insurance and Medicare	Hospitalizations in the weeks after cold snaps

The randomized evidence compares high-dose with standard-dose vaccine. DANFLU-2 (Denmark, 2025) missed its primary endpoint. A pooled analysis found 515 people need vaccinating to prevent one all-cause hospitalization (FLUNITY-HD, Sanofi-funded).*

Mortality reductions from cohort studies are inflated by healthy-user bias. Claim fewer hospitalizations, not deaths averted.

14. Send meal packs home with students for the winter break

UNVERIFIED | FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Weld RE-4 Nutrition Services, with the food banks	Before the late-December break	$15–25 per child (lens estimate, unverified)	A holiday hunger gap

SUN Bucks runs only in summer, by statute. No winter-break program was found in Colorado or in RE-4.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Confirm the need and the cost with the district before funding.

15. Hold insurance check-up sessions for manufactured-home owners

UNVERIFIED ECONOMIST ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Colorado Division of Insurance	Winter 2026–27	Staff time	Uninsured total loss

Colorado homeowner premiums rose 18.3% in 2025, to an average of about $4,310 (LendingTree). 76% of insurers cut the number of Coloradans they cover. A CU Boulder study found 74% of Marshall Fire owners underinsured; the Division of Insurance's own estimate is 36–67%.

No mobile-home park in Windsor itself could be identified. The national figure of about 35% of manufactured homes uninsured is also unverified, and no 2026 schedule of Division of Insurance sessions was found.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue	Weld & Larimer OEM / LETA	Town of Windsor	CDOT & State Patrol	Weld & Larimer human services / aging	Food bank & pantry	Red Cross / United Way / partners
1. Smoke and CO alarm installs	R		I		C		A/R
2. Alert sign-up drive and test	C	A/R	R			C	
3. Snow clearing for older men	I		C		A/R		R
4. Winter posture to 30 April	C	C	A/R	C			
5. Medical certificates, LEAP, PVREA ask			C		A/R	C	R
6. Corridor closure triggers	C	R	C	A/R			
7. Spanish trusted-voice messaging	A/R	C	I				R
8. Pantry address rule and cash						A/R	C
9. SNAP exemption screening					A/R	C	
10. Cold-weather shelter overflow		I			C		A/R
11. Flat-roof snow list	R	I	A/R				
12. Red Flag fire posture	A/R	C	I				
13. Vaccination drive, 65+			I		A/R		C
14. Winter-break meal packs					C	A/R	
15. Insurance check-ups			C		I		A/R

What the chart shows: county human services and aging agencies are accountable for the most rows (four). The Red Cross, United Way, and partner organizations carry the most work (six rows with an R). The fire district holds the referral lists everything else depends on. Rows 4, 6, and 8 need a decision rather than money. Action 13 sits with public health inside the human-services column. Action 15 sits with the Colorado Division of Insurance in the partners column.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR
$30,000

TARGET
$65,000

CEILING
$160,000

LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
How many eligible low-income older homes Windsor actually has (median

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

	household income $127,028; poverty 5.97%)

The arithmetic:

- **Floor:** alarms $30,000.
- **Target:** alarms $30,000 + shelter overflow $15,000 + pantry $10,000 + LEAP outreach $10,000 = $65,000.
- **Ceiling:** alarms for 1,000 homes $75,000 + shelter overflow $35,000 + pantry $10,000 + LEAP outreach $10,000 + an unrestricted Energy Outreach Colorado gift $30,000 = $160,000.
- **Movement:** the target fell 58% from the lens's $155,000. Almost all of the cut is a $90,000 furnace placement that duplicated a state programme.
- **Caveat:** 1,000 low-income homes with residents 65 and over may exceed the eligible pool in a town of about 40,000.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
American Red Cross, Northern Colorado (Windsor-Severance Fire Rescue refers)	Action 1: combination alarms installed	$30,000	Restricted grant	Smoke-alarm installation: $28,252 per death averted (Diamond-Smith 2014, Baltimore); $45,630 per QALY (Liu 2012). No outcome data exist for the carbon monoxide half	Partially confirmed
United Way of Weld County Cold Weather Shelter	Action 10: hotel overflow on full nights	$15,000	Restricted grant	60 beds at capacity in December 2024. No cost per death averted is published	Partially confirmed (redirected from Guadalupe)
Windsor-Severance Food Pantry	Action 8: storm-week contingency	$10,000	Grant	Food security, not mortality. No evidence of the pantry's budget scale	Partially confirmed
To be named (county human services or a partner)	Action 5: LEAP sign-up outreach	$10,000	Grant, conditional on a named grantee	Leverage on a $355 average benefit; unmeasured	Unverified

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The funder's one thing: Windsor is affluent, and the El Niño signal here is weak, so this is ordinary winter-safety money with an El Niño label. Fund the floor in Windsor, where installing alarms is cheap and proven. Send the rest to Greeley and wider Weld County, where the same dollar reaches poorer and older households. Do not spend up to the ceiling just because Windsor could absorb it.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Do not run a "big El Niño snow year, get ready" campaign

CONTRAINDICATED

The Colorado Climate Center finds no El Niño precipitation signal in Colorado and calls the blizzard link "not consistent enough to... use it as a forecast." In 2023, the moisture expected from El Niño did not arrive. A snow-themed campaign uses up the attention that wind, fire, shutoffs, and carbon monoxide need. Those killers strike in any ENSO phase: the Marshall Fire burned in a La Niña December, and the 2024 shutoff came in April.

Instead: prepare for one large upslope storm in October or March, for cold snaps, and for wind-driven grass fire.

Do not tell people to "get a generator", or run one in the garage with the door open *

CONTRAINDICATED

A Broomfield man died with a generator running in his garage while heating his home. A couple died after using propane heaters indoors during a blizzard. Outages from storms and shutoffs push people toward improvised heat.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: installed carbon monoxide alarms (action 1), "never in the garage, even with the door open," and Xcel medical certification for people who depend on powered devices (action 5).

Do not make a ZIP-restricted furnace gift to Energy Outreach Colorado's Crisis Intervention Program

CONTRAINDICATED

The program is publicly funded through the Colorado Department of Human Services and serves only LEAP-approved homeowners. A $90,000 gift restricted to Windsor would duplicate a state program in a town with a 5.97% poverty rate. The $6,000-per-job figure behind it was unsourced.

Instead: enroll eligible households in LEAP (action 5), which opens the furnace program to them. Give an unrestricted gift only at the ceiling.

Do not send overflow money to the Guadalupe Shelter

CONTRAINDICATED AS SPECIFIED

Guadalupe (now Samaritan House) no longer hosts overflow. Single-adult overflow is the United Way of Weld County Cold Weather Shelter.

Instead: fund hotel overflow at the United Way shelter (action 10).

Do not ask for proof of address before handing out USDA food, and do not tell drivers simply to "drive carefully"

CONTRAINDICATED

Federal rules have barred an address or ID requirement for TEFAP food since 30 December 2024, and the request deters exactly the households most at risk. On the roads, the 2019 pileup and the death of a trooper on I-76 show that careful driving is not the protection; not being on the road is.

Instead: self-attestation at the pantry (action 8), and early closures plus employer shift cancellations (action 6).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
24 Dec 1982 (El Niño)	Christmas Eve blizzard, 24–34 in across the Denver metro area	3–5 dead statewide	Nothing recorded for Windsor
28 Jul 1997	Spring Creek flood, Fort Collins (a developing El Niño; monsoon rain)	5 dead; more than $200M damage	The volunteer rain-gauge network built afterward became the national CoCoRaHS network
24–25 Oct 1997 (El Niño)	Blizzard; 17.5 in at Fort Collins	4–7 dead statewide, mostly in southern Colorado. Three El Paso County deaths were carbon monoxide in stranded vehicles	Nothing recorded
17–19 Mar 2003 (El Niño)	Upslope blizzard; 32.2 in at CSU, Fort Collins' biggest on record	More than 100 roofs collapsed in Denver; in Fort Collins, 37 structures destroyed (secondary account)	Forecasting improved
22 May 2008	EF3 tornado through Windsor, tracking north-northwest	1 dead (a man fleeing a trailer park in his motor home); 78 injured; about 850 homes damaged; $147M insured	Windsor and Greeley chose not to install sirens
Sep 2013	Front Range floods (ENSO-neutral)	In Weld, about 3,000 homes affected and 122 bridges damaged	Drainage projects
13 Mar 2019 (weak El Niño)	Bomb cyclone	A pileup of about 100 vehicles near Wellington; about 1,100 stranded; Cpl. Daniel Groves killed on I-76	CDOT's "shelter sooner" guidance
30 Dec 2021 (La Niña)	Marshall Fire, Boulder County	The worst property loss in Colorado history; opt-in alerts reached few people	Wireless Emergency Alerts used more widely

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
6–7 Apr 2024	Xcel public safety power shutoff	55,000 customers shut off	PUC investigation and improvements ordered
Nov 2025	Weld CodeRED cyberattack; federal shutdown and SNAP lapse	Alerts offline for about five weeks; about 2,200 people at the Weld Food Bank in one day	CodeRED rebuilt from a March 2025 backup

The recurrence nobody has noticed: El Niño's storms here did not come in midwinter. They came on Christmas Eve, in late October, in mid-March, and in a July flood. Windsor's worst day came from a direction nobody expected, and the town then chose not to install sirens. Its safety now rests on whether residents are actually signed up.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE

UNRESOLVED

- **A colder winter** (the Colorado Climate Center's El Niño composite) versus **a warmer one** (CPC's 17 September 2026 outlook for the northern tier). CPC's 15 October issue may settle it for this season. Neither changes the actions.
- **A weather problem** versus **a policy problem**. The Food Supply Chain lens argues that the SNAP time limit and federal cuts will do more harm here this winter than El Niño. The other lenses treat winter weather as the hazard. Both belong in the plan.
- **Spend in Windsor** versus **spend in Greeley and wider Weld**. The Philanthropist, backed by the envelope verifier, says the floor belongs in Windsor and the rest elsewhere. A funder focused on this town alone would disagree.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED

BLIND SPOT

No lens found where Windsor's most vulnerable residents actually live. No mobile-home park in Windsor itself could be identified, the farmworker count could not be confirmed, and the 55-and-over communities were not mapped. Every outreach action here depends on referral lists the fire district and the aging agencies hold, and no one has yet asked for them. No lens checked whether the town's own budget has an emergency-management line.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

HOW TO READ THIS METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The location was taken as given: Windsor, Colorado, a town of about 40,000 (and therefore below the resolution of the mortality data). Climate Impact Lab impact region, as the report records it: not resolved; the town lies mostly in Weld County, with part in Larimer. Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); town-level detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief: an emergency manager, a public health scientist, a frontline responder, a skeptic, an economist, a historian, a philanthropist, and a food supply chain analyst. State-level context was cross-checked against the earlier Boulder, Colorado briefing; nothing was reused unverified.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Five separate verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). The

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five covered alerts, roads, and climate; health; financial instruments; food and outreach; and the funding envelope. Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.

- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted. The inventory renders client-side, and the verifier's fetch returned 0 entries and an empty country list. No action here should be read as lacking a precedent; it was not checked.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (cold-weather shelter, vaccines, generators, heaters, carbon monoxide, and powered medical devices) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. Also:
  - The impact region was not resolved.
  - The town's alert page (windsorco.gov/1414) returned 403.
  - CPC's October outlook was two days away.
  - No current Colorado count of carbon monoxide deaths was found.
  - The Windsor budget PDF was not read.
  - The alarm and meal-pack unit costs are lens estimates.

References (✓ verified by a verifier agent against the primary source · ~ partly verified or secondary · ? not verified) · ✓ Colorado Climate Center, ENSO and Colorado · ✓ CPC seasonal outlook discussion · ~ Axios Denver, 2026–27 winter outlook · ✓ Weld CodeRED back online · ✓ NOCO

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Alert and IPAWS · ✓ Why Windsor and Greeley have no sirens · ✓ NWS, 22 May 2008 tornado · ✓ CSU, warning response in 2008 · ✓ NWS, March 2019 bomb cyclone · ✓ CDOT, shelter sooner · ✓ NWS, October 1997 blizzard · ✓ Colorado Climate Center, March 2003 · ✓ NASA, March 2003 blizzard · ~ UPI, December 1982 blizzard · ~ CSU, Spring Creek flood · ~ 2013 Front Range flood report · ✓ PUC, April 2024 shutoffs · ~ Colorado Sun, Marshall Fire alerts · ✓ Diamond-Smith et al. 2014, smoke alarm installation · ✓ Liu, Mack, and Diekman 2012 · ✓ Colorado HB09-1091 · ✓ CO alarm laws and mortality, 2023 · ✓ Storm-related CO outbreaks, Connecticut · ✓ Red Cross and Greeley Fire alarm installs, 2025 · ✓ Auger et al. 2017, snowfall and MI · ✓ Weld Chore Service · ✓ Larimer Chore Voucher · ✓ Weld AAA minutes, cold-weather shelter · ✓ Denver homeless deaths, 2018 · ~ FLUNITY-HD · ✓ Energy Outreach Colorado CIP · ✓ Larimer LEAP · ✓ Weld energy assistance · ✓ CDHS, LEAP 2024–25 · ✓ CRS, LIHEAP FY2027 · ✓ PUC cold-weather disconnection rule · ~ PVREA rules (2021 draft) · ~ Xcel medical-device programs · ✓ LendingTree, home insurance 2025 · ✓ CPR, Marshall Fire underinsurance · ✓ Weld Food Bank demand · ✓ Colorado Newsline, SNAP pause · ✓ Windsor-Severance Food Pantry · ✓ USDA, TEFAP eligibility rule · ✓ USDA ERS Food Price Outlook · ✓ USDA, SNAP time-limit waivers FY26 · ✓ Weld SNAP recipients · ✓ Food Bank for Larimer County · ~ KGRE (dated) · ✓ Census QuickFacts, Windsor · ✓ Data USA, Windsor income and poverty

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 13 October 2026 for Windsor, Colorado. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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